Dr. Kimberlee Armstrong, Superintendent
Members of the Board of Education
Portland Public Schools
501 N. Dixon Street
Portland, OR 97227

VIA EMAIL

October 20, 2026

Re: Seismic safety implications of the proposed Rightsizing scenarios

Dear Superintendent Armstrong and Members of the Board:

On behalf of Safe Structures PPS, I write to express our concerns regarding certain aspects of PPS recently announced Rightsizing scenarios. At the outset, we want to acknowledge the real pressures behind the Rightsizing proposals – the complicated dynamics faced by the district are not easily solved. That said, comparing the district's proposed scenarios against the Holmes seismic assessment and the 2025 Bond seismic plan raises several concerns that, in our view, PPS must answer publicly before the Board determines a path forward on Rightsizing.

Both scenarios would do little to reduce the number of students in the highest-risk buildings

We appreciate that both scenarios would reduce the number of students attending the district's unreinforced masonry (URM) schools. Our analysis of the publicly available data, using PPS's 2028 enrollment estimates (the first year with full projections for every scenario), indicates that the number of students attending URM schools would fall from about 3,139 to about 2,725.[1] Structural engineers have warned that URM buildings could collapse even in a moderate earthquake, so this is a real gain for student safety.

However, the same analysis indicates that neither scenario would meaningfully reduce the number of students in schools with at least one building posing the greatest seismic risk according to the 2025 Holmes report (i.e., schools with at least one building part rated 9 or higher on the Holmes 10-point risk scale). Under the status quo, about 9,700 students (37%) would attend such schools in 2028. Under Scenario A, that number would rise by 400, to 10,089 (39%). Under Scenario B, it would be essentially unchanged, increasing from 9,689 to 9,709 (remaining 37% of students). In other words, a once-in-a-generation reshuffling of school assignments would still leave nearly four in ten elementary and middle school students in schools with the highest-risk buildings.

Elementary and middle schools	Status quo	Scenario A	Scenario B
Students in URM schools (after planned retrofits)	3,139 (12%)	2,725 (10%)	2,723 (10%)
Students at schools with a part rated 9+	9,689 (37%)	10,089 (39%)	9,709 (37%)

[1] Note that under Scenario A, Rose City Park is slated for closure, but given that under the status quo it is slated for a full seismic retrofit, we are not counting that as an overall reduction in the number of students attending URM schools.

Source: Safe Structures PPS analysis of Holmes risk scores and PPS 2028 enrollment estimates for each scenario.

This reflects where displaced students and programs would go. Both scenarios close several high-risk schools. Yet roughly 1,500 to 1,900 of the students at those high-risk schools would be added to other schools that score 9.0 or higher on the Holmes risk scale, including Rieke (9.6), Roseway Heights (9.3), Rigler (9.2), César Chávez (9.1), Ockley Green (9.1), Boise-Eliot (9.1), Abernethy (9.1), Brentwood (9.0), and Hosford (9.0). None of these schools is in the 2025 bond's first round of seismic projects. Moreover, about 400 of these students would move into URM schools with no scheduled seismic retrofit: Rigler, Abernethy, and Rieke. In light of the well-documented seismic risks faced by the district – not to mention the extensive time and effort to address those risks through multiple rounds of bond funding – we find it concerning that the district's own scenario comparison measures sustainability, student moves, and equity, but includes no seismic measure. That is difficult to square with PPS' commitment that "safe and healthy learning environments" is one of the guiding principles for this work.

Closures overlap heavily with schools that have received, or were promised, seismic investment

Both Scenarios also raise questions about prudent management of PPS' expenditure of bond funds allocated for seismic mitigation. Many of the schools proposed for closure are the same schools the district has recently retrofitted or has committed to retrofit with resources from the 2025 Bond:

- **Beach** is one of the nine schools in the 2025 bond's first round of seismic projects (a targeted retrofit that is projected to cost roughly $10 million, scheduled for summer 2028). It closes under both scenarios.
- **Rose City Park** is one of only two schools selected for a full campus retrofit in that round. It closes under Scenario A.
- **Marysville** completed a seismic retrofit of about $7 million in September 2026. It closes under both scenarios. We also note that $2.5 million of the Marysville retrofit was funded through the state Seismic Rehabilitation Grant Program, which would appear to require PPS to continue operating Marysville as a school for 10 years or risk having to repay the grant.
- **Lewis** received a seismic retrofit of about $1.2 million. It closes under Scenario A.
- **Sellwood Middle School, Maplewood, Stephenson, and Sabin** together received about $4.8 million in roof-level seismic improvements. All close under Scenario A, and all but Stephenson under Scenario B.

Media reports estimate that nearly $18 million has already been spent on upgrades at schools on the closure lists, with about $40 million more planned between Rose City Park and Beach.[2] In September 2025, district leadership said seismic priorities would account for "anticipated impacts of potential school consolidation." This month, the district told reporters that bond project selection and closure planning are two separate processes. It is not clear how these two statements can be reconciled.

There is no plan for 2025 bond seismic funds committed to schools that may close

While it was anticipated that the Rightsizing process could impact the district's seismic plan finalized in November 2025, we urge PPS to be transparent and specific about how it will amend the seismic plan

[2] We also note with some concern that media reports concerning the seismic retrofits planned for Rose City Park seem to have inaccurately stated both the total cost of the planned retrofits and lumped together roof repairs with the 2025 bond-funded seismic retrofits, apparently based on information provided by PPS.

based on those impacts. The November 2025 seismic plan was the product of many months of work - the Board adopted Resolution 7109 in May 2025, Holmes completed a districtwide assessment, and staff built a weighted scoring model and aligned their recommendations to a $100 million seismic budget, as presented to the Facilities Improvement and Oversight Committee in November 2025. That process produced a list of nine schools for the first round of bond-funded seismic work.

At least one and possibly two of those nine schools are now proposed for closure, yet PPS has not said what would happen to the bond funds committed to them (as noted above, more than $40 million total). PPS has not said whether those funds would go to the next-highest-risk schools, to the high-risk schools receiving displaced students, or elsewhere. To assure the PPS community – not to mention the voters who supported the bond itself – PPS must do more to outline how it will reallocate any funds that for planned retrofits at schools now slated to be closed. It also must ensure those plans are consistent with the mandate the Board imposed through Resolution 7109, which presumes that the first and highest use of these funds is to address the seismic mitigations needed at the 8–10 schools posing the greatest risk of injury or death, and it requires a written showing and Board approval to deviate from that presumption. It also directs the district to communicate clearly how retrofits are sequenced and to report quarterly on funding used and any schedule changes.

Beyond the 2025 Bond funds, PPS has also not yet addressed what it plans to do with the buildings that already received significant investment of prior bond resources – when asked about closed buildings, the district has said only that it "will develop a process to evaluate how the building could be used in the future." We are well beyond the point where such generic, noncommittal statements are enough. The lack of any apparent plan would not seem to comport with the Board's responsibility to manage bond funds prudently and with the commitments in Resolution 7109.

What we ask

We ask that PPS management and the Board respond publicly to the following questions before the Board decides on a path forward for Rightsizing:

1. How does each scenario change the number of students attending schools with building parts rated 9 or higher, and with URM buildings? Will PPS add these measures to its scenario comparison?
2. Were the Holmes risk scores and the 2025 bond seismic plan considered in choosing which schools would close and which would receive students? If so, how?
3. If Beach or Rose City Park closes, where will the 2025 bond seismic funds committed to them go, by what criteria, and on what timeline?
4. What will PPS do with the schools slated for closure that already received significant retrofits through prior bond funding?
5. What is the plan and schedule for seismic work at the high-risk schools that would receive displaced students and programs?

Portland voters approved the 2025 bond with a clear expectation that it would make the most dangerous schools safer, including a significant investment in PPS' elementary and middle schools. Rightsizing will shape where students learn for decades. It was always understood that the Rightsizing initiative might impact the seismic plan, but that does not relieve PPS of its ongoing responsibility to implement seismic plan with the urgency called for under Resolution 7109. PPS needs to clarify how it intends to do so with more than just general statements about a future process to determine any needed reallocation of funds.

We would welcome the opportunity to meet with district staff and Board members to discuss these concerns.

Respectfully,



Per Olstad
Safe Structures PPS